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Ria An

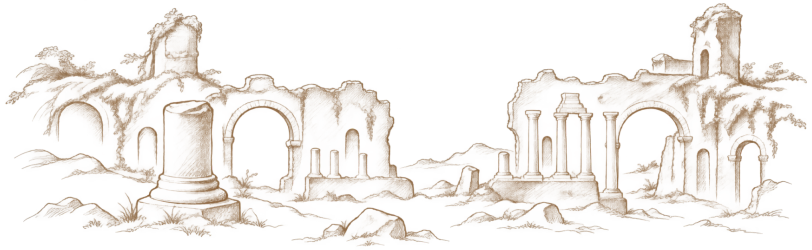


Mount Etna from Taormina, Thomas Cole, 1843

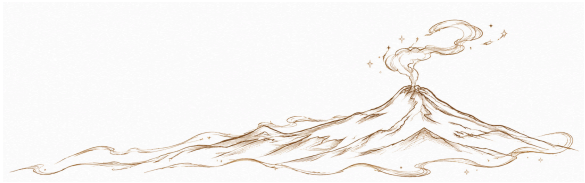
Letter to Reader

Growing up as an only child, building worlds was a daily hobby—whether through books, movies, series, or art, I was constantly imagining.

Land remembers life. And this painting's landscape was caught between destruction and rebirth, an invitation to *imagine*.



Prelude



There are nights when even mountains dream.

Beneath a quilt of stars, il Monte Etna lay in a slumber, its ancient shoulders draped in silver moonlight. Thin wisps of smoke curled lazily from its summit like the slow breaths of a sleeping giant, unraveling into the velvet dark. The night herself dared not disturb its dreams, hushing the clouds.

The father gazed at the mountain for a moment before turning to the two boys, tucking them snugly beneath a shared blanket, their tousled heads peeking out side by side.

“Have I ever told you the tale of Caelen the Mender?”

“The one who fought the mountain?” The younger one piped up, his sky blue eyes lighting up at the promise of a story.

“Fought?” The father lightly shook his head. “Oh, no. Caelen was no warrior. He carried neither sword nor shield; only a hammer, a sack of iron stakes as big as himself, and a rather...” He stroked his chin thoughtfully. “Ah, let’s say, destructive hunger for glory.”

“Then why do they call him a hero?” the older boy asked, his piercing silver eyes, so unmistakably his father’s, glinting with curiosity.

“Patience, son. Every good tale must begin at the beginning.”

He eased himself into the chair beside their bed, its wooden legs groaning softly beneath his weight.

“Long before our kingdom bore its name, Etna was a fearsome beast. Day and night, the earth trembled with its fury—rivers of fire devoured the forests, leaving the valleys choking beneath blankets of ash, and the mountain wept molten tears that scorched all they touched. No king, no army, not even the wisest sorcerers could quiet its rage.”

The younger boy’s glance darted nervously toward the window before burrowing closer to the older one.

“But there was one man,” the father continued, raising a finger, “not Caelen, but his elder brother, a warrior of such renown that his name was sung from one end of the kingdom to the other. Wherever he rode, crowds knelt in worship. Wherever he fought, painters immortalized his victories, and minstrels wove his name into another song. And so, wherever Caelen went, he was greeted by only one name: brother of the Great Warrior.”

The younger one wrinkled his nose. “Didn’t they know his real name?”

“Well, knowing and remembering are two very different things.”

“Was Caelen angry?”

“Perhaps. He loved his brother, as brothers ought to.”

The father paused, his gaze settling on the two boys nestled together. Only one carried his blood. The other bore the eyes of his dearest friend: once his sword arm in battle, his closest confidant in peace, and, in the end, the reason he still drew breath until this day. He had brought the orphaned child home, and somewhere amid scraped knees and shared mischief, the two had forgotten their different roots, only remembering they grew beneath the same sky.

A tender smile touched his lips.

“But love, my boys, is a peculiar thing. Sometimes it sits beside envy, and neither knows when the other has arrived. Tell me, would you not grow jealous if the whole kingdom praised your brother’s name but scarcely remembered yours?”

“I wouldn’t,” the younger declared solemnly.

His brother grinned, nudging him beneath the quilt. “Is that why you insist on racing me up the stairs every night?”

The younger boy opened his mouth in protest, but their father interrupted with a chuckle. “Perhaps not. But Caelen yearned for something greater than victory. Night after night, he whispered a wish to the moon, for his brother’s name to fade into oblivion and his own to live forever. And one night, the moon, hearing his plea, stretched a silver finger across the heavens and laid it upon the mountain.”

He nodded toward the window, where Etna’s silhouette gleamed beneath that very moon.

“So, while his brother marched to war, Caelen set out to conquer something no sword could touch. For seven days and seven nights, he drove his stakes into the mountain’s burning fissures, sealing each wound. And alas, the mountain fell silent.”

“He saved everyone!” the younger boy exclaimed.

“Almost. One hole remained. Though his family begged him to stop, Caelen was drunk on something sweeter than victory: the sound of his own name upon a thousand tongues.”

The father’s voice dwindled to a grim whisper. “And so, he struck the final stake.”

A passing draft set the candle trembling, its flame casting restless shadows across the walls.

“Etna awoke with a roar that tore through the heavens and hell; fire swallowed the summit, and the greatest eruption in history engulfed Caelen. And from his ashes and tears, a new kingdom arose. *Our* kingdom.”

“Then he became greater than his brother?” the older boy asked.

“Remembered, yes,” his father replied, a wistful smile crossing his face. "Whether that made him greater, my sons, is for you to decide."

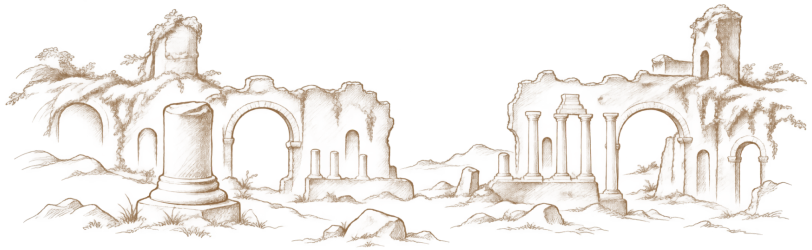
The younger boy frowned, his brows knitting together. “But how do we know he was ever real?”

“Why,” the father exclaimed, leaning forward with a mischievous glimmer in his eyes, “Etna still spits out his teeth!”

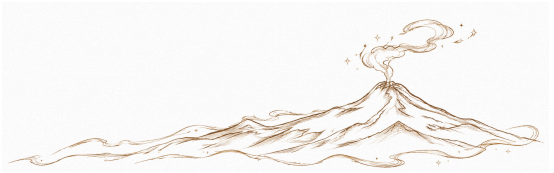
With a squeak, the younger boy vanished beneath the quilt, drawing laughter from the other two. The father rose, smoothing the quilt over their shoulders. He pressed a kiss on each forehead, whispering his goodnights before extinguishing the candle.

Outside, Etna snored beneath its blanket of stars, and the younger boy was quick to follow. The older one, though, lay awake, listening to the mountain’s raspy breaths. His thoughts drifted to the Great Warrior, whose victories had once filled a kingdom with song, yet whose name even his father could not recall. To Caelen, whose final folly had somehow become his greatest triumph. To the strange mercy of history, which could fashion a kingdom’s beginning from a man’s ruin, and crown with glory the very hand that brought destruction.

And he wondered, with faint unease, how many names had been forgotten so that one might be remembered.



Prologue



Remember, dear boy. The Mountain never forgets.

Hidden in the shadows of a secluded balcony above the grand hall, his fingers gripped the edges of the broken windowsill as he peered into the mansion’s marble floor sprawling beneath him. Jagged glass still clung like broken teeth to the blackened frame, moonlight glinting from the shards in ghostly, shivering sparks. The rough stone was exquisitely carved with the sweeping contours of il Monte Etna, iron veins fractured by fresh cracks. Beneath his fingertips rose faint warmth through the stone, the mountain’s heat buried deep within. There was a vicious split down the middle, a wound letting in a sharp blade of night air. Frost had settled along its edges, biting into his skin, yet he did not seem to notice.

The boy only noticed the sound.

A dozen bodies hit the flagstones in a single, ugly rhythm, shattering knees as the warriors were thrust roughly to the ground. One fell sideways with a grunt and was not given a chance to push himself upright as a soldier forcefully caught him by the hair. The clanking of chains followed, the wet metallic scraping twisting low in his stomach.

High-pitched laughter and retching tangled in the bitter wind. As the smell of burning pitch reached the window, thick enough to taste, he breathed through his mouth until his teeth ached with cold.

“Coward,” the man spat at the woman staring down from the dais. *His* dais.

The man’s mouth was split, fresh blood trickling every time he spoke. Silver flashed and rebelled against the dried blood caked to his hair. There was a nasty cut along his brow that poured slowly a steady line that carved his face in a deep shade of molten red. He blinked hard, trying to clear one eye. Even stripped of his cloak and forced onto his knees, the air around him whirled like a blizzard, angrily sweeping through the fallen pillars that once stood tall and proud.

The boy leaned forward. He knew those obstinate shoulders. He knew the way that head tilted before a strict reprimand, before a roaring laugh. He desperately willed the kneeling man—his father—to wrench his hands free, to plant one boot after another beneath him, rolling those shoulders as though the chains had merely been an ill-fitting coat.

Torches shuddered, flames leaning in as if they, too, were listening.

The woman’s lips curled into a thin sneer full of open disdain. Her eyes flickered away from the man, sweeping around her soldiers, then upward. Her gaze passed over the lower windows. The boy went rigid as her eyes, glinting with the patient hunger of a vulture, wandered across the wrecked mansion. Should he hide? After a few precious seconds, he thought better of it, shuddering at the thought of a loose stone crumbling beneath his fingers, its faint clatter enough to draw her predatory gaze toward him. Perhaps even the thunder of his heart had betrayed him. Had she seen him? Her expression betrayed nothing.

“Tonight marks the start of an era for our kingdom,” her voice rang along the stone floor, deep yet shrill, her grin even wider as she faced her soldiers once again. “Taormina is free of its traitors.”

The soldiers reacted as one creature. A howl rose, full of avarice and cruel pride, the vicious racket sending chills up the boy’s spine. Boots stamped as spear hafts struck stone. Glass trembled against his whitened knuckles.

The woman raised her palm. All shouting faltered, and a final spear haft struck the stone, its lone crack ringing through the sudden hush.

“Traitors?” The father barked out a short, incredulous laugh. Iron scraped stone as he pulled against his chains. “You know what lies beneath us. You saw it.” His voice had a note of plea in it this time. “When we’re dead, and you can still hear it beneath your feet, whose throat will you slit then?”

Her lips parted, but whatever words had gathered on her tongue withered into silence. She lowered her hand, refusing to look at the man in the eye.

“Kill them.” It was barely more than a whisper, yet it bounced endlessly through the pillars.

The boy tried to swallow, but his throat refused to obey. For one foolish heartbeat, he thought nothing would happen.

Metal hissed as swords slid from their sheathes, met by echoes of guttural screams torn loose.

Nausea slammed into him, a cold, merciless swell that left him reeling. His vision narrowed, the torches below smearing into streaks of golden orange. His fists clenched harder on the sill, oblivious of the thick blood oozing out as his pulse thundered in his ears. The boy’s stomach twisted into a vicious knot, forcing him against the sill, his teeth clenched against the bitter surge rising in his throat.

Beside him, the smaller one shifted, a tremor traveling through his shoulders to his fingers. He was just tall enough to peek through the glasses. Those delicate fingers were tangled in the boy’s shirt, clutching cloth so hard the stitching threatened to snap. His grip was warm—too warm for the cold night.

His father’s words echoed in his memory, spoken only hours before in this very room. He could almost feel the warmth of his father kneeling before him, the comforting scent of leather and woodsmoke still vivid. *Trust only each other. He’s your family*, he had said.

The boy had opened his mouth to ask where he was going, but his father’s grip tightened around his shoulders. Wincing, he could only watch his father tear his restless gaze from the open door and fix it upon him with an urgency that demanded a promise. The boy nodded, though he understood nothing, compelled by the unfamiliar glimmer of fear in his father's eyes. A rough thumb brushed gently across his cheek, lingering as his father breathed the final word: *Remember*.

A sharp sting jolted him back to the frigid night. Blood was gushing out of a deep gash on his left palm. The warmth of it was a shock, as if his body had decided this was the moment to remind him it was alive.

He turned abruptly, heart still slamming against his ribcage, his father’s voice ringing through the chaos of his thoughts. Almost instinctively, his trembling hands flew to the smaller boy’s ears, squeezing tight. The child startled, eyes going wide, their electric blue flashing in the darkness.

Forcing his lungs to work, he brought his right hand up, palm flat, closing those bright eyes with a swift motion. The lashes fluttered against his skin, wet, and the child’s breath hit his wrist in quick bursts as he returned his hands to the younger one’s ears, as though he could shut out the horror beyond them.

What you bury, the stones will remember. It shall return in the brightest flames.

The boy closed his own tempestuous eyes.

Remember, dear boy. The Mountain never forgets.